Use ChatGPT to Prepare for Your Elder Law Attorney Meeting

Four prompts to list the documents you have, write down who they name, lay out the facts about the house and any transfers, and gather your questions for the attorney.

Where you are

Mom needs care now, and the legal questions arrived all at once: who can act for her, whether the power of attorney is enough, what happens with the house. The papers are in different places and nobody is sure what they say.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names and account numbers removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not give legal advice, interpret documents, or decide. Rules vary by state. Bring legal questions to an elder law attorney.

What you'll have at the end

You know which documents exist and where they are, you've written down the facts an attorney will ask about, and your questions are in one place.

A one-page list: Documents we have, Documents we can't find, Facts an attorney will need, and Questions we need answered, with who to ask.

Before you start

- Whatever legal papers you can put your hands on: a power of attorney, healthcare documents, a will, a trust, the deed.
- A rough list of what your parent owns and how each thing is titled, as far as you know.
- Notes on any gifts, transfers, or ownership changes already made or being discussed. You don't need everything.

PROMPT 1

Start with the papers you can find

WHY THIS MATTERS

When care is needed now, the legal papers tend to be in three different places and nobody has read them recently. Before an attorney can say whether they do the job, someone has to know which ones exist.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Whatever you've found so far: the type of document, the date on it, and where it is. A rough list is fine.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the legal documents my family has found for my mother, with what I know about each one (type, date signed, where it is kept):

> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Using only what I've written, make a table: document, date, where it is kept, and who has a copy. Then list the common document types I haven't mentioned (durable power of attorney, healthcare documents, will, trust, deed) under HAVEN'T FOUND OR DON'T KNOW. Do not tell me what any document means or whether it is valid.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A plain inventory with dates and locations, and a clear list of what hasn't turned up.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask close relatives about the papers on the not-found list, and add what turns up.

PROMPT 2

Write down who the documents name

WHY THIS MATTERS

One of the first things an attorney will ask is who is named to act for your parent, and in which document. Whether that authority is enough for what lies ahead is the attorney's question to answer, not yours and not the AI's.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The documents from the first prompt, or your notes on them: who is named as agent, successor, trustee, or healthcare decision-maker.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my mother's documents say, in my own words, about who is named to act for her (agent, successor agent, trustee, healthcare decision-maker):
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Using only what I've written, list each document, who it names, and anything I marked as unclear. Then list what I haven't said, as questions. Do not tell me whether anyone has legal authority or whether a document is sufficient; mark those as questions for an elder law attorney.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A simple who-is-named-where list, with the unclear parts turned into questions.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put the questions about authority at the top of your list for the attorney.

PROMPT 3

Lay out the facts about the house and any transfers

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families in this situation often talk about putting the house in someone's name or moving money. How any of that would be treated depends on the details and on your state, so the useful thing to do now is get the facts straight and bring the decisions to the attorney.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What your parent owns and how each thing is titled, as far as you know, plus any gifts, transfers, or ownership changes already made or being discussed.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I know about my mother's home and other property, how each is titled, and any gifts, transfers, or ownership changes that have been made or that the family is considering:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Using only what I've written, organize this into three lists: WHAT SHE OWNS AND HOW IT IS TITLED, CHANGES ALREADY MADE (with dates if I gave them), and CHANGES BEING CONSIDERED. Mark anything I was unsure of. Do not tell me how Medicaid would treat any of it or whether a change is a good idea.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Facts in one place, with dates where you have them, and no opinions about what they mean.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Bring this list to the attorney before anything on the being-considered list is acted on.

PROMPT 4

Gather your questions and sort them by who can answer

WHY THIS MATTERS

Some questions the family can settle by finding a paper or asking a relative. Others belong to an elder law attorney, and some to your Medicaid planner. Knowing which is which makes the attorney meeting more useful.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've organized about my mother's legal documents, property, and transfers:
>
> [PASTE EVERYTHING FROM PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Give me one page with four headings: DOCUMENTS WE HAVE, DOCUMENTS WE CAN'T FIND, FACTS AN ATTORNEY WILL NEED, and QUESTIONS WE NEED ANSWERED. Under the last heading, mark each question with who should answer it: family, an elder law attorney, a Medicaid planner, or not sure. Do not answer the legal questions or recommend a strategy.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

One page you could hand to an attorney and have them see where things stand.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the page. It's the start of the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've organized the legal side of what you know. The next step is the planning interview, which produces a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner and to an elder law attorney.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›